

Anemarrhena asphodeloides (Liliaceae)

Zhi Mu

Description Perennial herb with a thick rhizome, thin leaves up to 28 in (70 cm) long, and clusters of small white or light purple flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to northern China, zhi mu grows wild on exposed slopes and hills. It is cultivated in the northern and north-eastern provinces.

Part Used Rhizome.

Constituents Contains steroidal saponins, lignans, phenolic compounds, and xanthones.

History & Folklore Zhi mu is first mentioned in the 1st-century CE herbal, the *Divine Husbandman's Classic* (Shen'ong Bencaojing).

Medicinal Actions & Uses Zhi mu has a bitter taste and a "cold" temperament and is used in Chinese herbal medicine for "excess heat"—fever, night sweats, and coughs. It has been shown to have significant antibacterial activity and is commonly used to treat sores and mouth ulcers.

Anemone pulsatilla syn. Pulsatilla vulgaris (Ranunculaceae)

Pulsatilla

Description Hairy perennial growing to 6 in (15 cm). Has feathery leaves, and large, purple-blue, bell-shaped flowers, with bright yellow anthers.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Europe, this herb thrives in dry grassland in central and northern parts of the continent, preferring chalky soil. The aerial parts are harvested when it flowers in spring.

Parts Used Dried aerial parts.

Constituents Pulsatilla contains the lactone protoanemonin (which on drying forms anemonin), triterpenoid saponins, tannins, and volatile oil.

History & Folklore In Greek mythology, the goddess Flora was jealous of her husband's attentions to the nymph Anemone and so transformed her into a flower; at the mercy of the North Wind. Anemone literally means "daughter of the wind" in Greek. The alternate name "pasque flower" derives from the French name for Easter, when the plant is often in flower.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Pulsatilla is less commonly used now in herbal medicine than in the past, though it is still considered a valuable remedy for cramping pain, menstrual problems, and emotional distress. It is considered a specific treatment for spasmodic pain of the reproductive system, both male and female, and is given quite

frequently for premenstrual syndrome and period pain, especially when these are accompanied by nervous exhaustion. In France, it has traditionally been used for treating coughs and as a sedative for sleep difficulties. Pulsatilla is also used to treat eye problems such as cataracts. The fresh plant is not used because it is strongly irritant. Pulsatilla is one of the most commonly used of all homeopathic remedies.

Related Species The meadow anemone (*A. pratensis*) is used interchangeably with pasque flower; wood anemone (*A. nemorosa*) is now rarely used in herbal medicine.

ⓘ Cautions Take only under professional supervision. Do not take during pregnancy. Do not take the fresh plant, which is toxic.

Anethum graveolens syn. Peucedanum graveolens (Apiaceae)

Dill

Description Aromatic annual that grows to a height of 30 in (75 cm). Has an erect hollow stem, feathery leaves, and numerous yellow flowers in umbels. Fruit is very lightweight and pungent.

Habitat & Cultivation Dill is native to southern Europe and central and southern Asia, growing wild in open areas. It is also widely cultivated, notably in England, Germany, and North America. The leaves are picked as a culinary herb. The seeds are harvested in late summer.

Parts Used Seeds, essential oil, leaves.

Constituents Dill seeds contain up to 5% volatile oil (about half of which is alpha-phellandrene), flavonoids, coumarins, xanthones, and triterpenes.

History & Folklore An ancient Egyptian remedy in the Ebers papyrus (c. 1500 BCE) recommends dill as one of the ingredients in a pain-killing mixture. The ancient Greeks are believed to have covered their eyes with fronds of the herb to induce sleep. Dill was commonly used as a charm against witchcraft in the Middle Ages, when it was burned to clear thunderclouds. Its name comes from the Norse *dylla*—meaning "to soothe."

Medicinal Actions & Uses Dill has always been considered a remedy for the stomach, relieving gas and calming digestion. Dill's essential oil relieves intestinal spasms and cramps and helps to settle colic, hence it is often used in gripe water mixtures. Chewing the seeds improves bad breath. Dill makes a useful addition to cough, cold, and flu remedies, and is a mild diuretic. Like caraway (*Carum carvi*, p. 184), it can be used with antispasmodics, such as cramp bark (*Viburnum opulus*, p. 150), to relieve period pain.

Dill increases milk production, and when taken regularly by nursing mothers, helps to prevent colic in their babies.

Caution Take the essential oil internally only under professional supervision.



Dill was used as a remedy by the ancient Greeks to encourage a good night's sleep.

Angelica archangelica (Apiaceae)

Angelica

Description Aromatic biennial herb growing to 6½ ft (2 m). Has ridged upright hollow stems, large bright green leaves, and greenish-white flowers in umbels.

Habitat & Cultivation Angelica grows in temperate regions in western Europe, Siberia, and the Himalayas. It prefers damp sites and is often found near running water. Leaves and stems are harvested in early summer; seeds as they ripen in late summer; and roots in late autumn after one year's growth.

Parts Used Root, leaves, stems, seeds.